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Co-creation and design of Agroforestry farming systems

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Agroforestry, a land-use and management practice that integrates trees, crops, and livestock, is promoted in northwestern Vietnam by local authorities and supported by international organizations. The aim is to enhance environmental sustainability and support livelihoods, particularly in resource-constrained areas. Farmers have been provided with tree seedlings and fertilizer to facilitate broader adoption. However, effective scaling of agroforestry involves more than just increasing its uptake. It necessitates focusing on learning, adapting, and community strengthening to ensure lasting impacts.

Our research employs systems and participatory approaches to evaluate how smallholder farmers adopt agroforestry and adapt it to their farming practices. The study reveals varied adoption trajectories, showing how farmers navigate and adapt to challenges through a whole-system approach to farm resource management. This approach allows them to leverage the benefits of agroforestry and adaptively manage challenges, drawing upon systemic understanding of trade-offs and synergies. Considering farmers' views and ways of reasoning during innovation processes may allow tailoring appropriate interventions that respect unique farm situations and local contexts. Such locally generated knowledge facilitates learning from varied farmer behaviors and strategies, which contribute to the co-creation and design of farming systems and ensure that interventions are practical and locally relevant.